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New legislation targets looters and imposters at disaster sites

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A new set of California public safety laws strengthening penalties for looting and the impersonation of emergency personnel during declared emergencies took effect this month, measures that were strongly supported by Ventura County District Attorney Erik Nasarenko.

The laws were signed by Gov. Gavin Newsom in October and consist of companion legislation in Assembly Bill 468 and Senate Bill 571.

AB 468, authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, whose district comprises western Los Angeles and eastern Ventura County communities, increases penalties for looting during declared emergencies, and extends those protections into the recovery and rebuilding phase following disasters. SB 571 strengthens penalties for individuals who impersonate firefighters, law enforcement officers or other officials during emergencies.

"Ventura County is no stranger to disaster, and our residents know firsthand how devastating these events can be," Nasarenko said in a statement.

"When families are evacuating from a dangerous fire and first responders are risking their lives, we can't have criminals exploiting the chaos and devastation.

"These new laws will allow us to crack down on looters and criminal impersonators," the DA said.

Gabriel said the legislation was intended to protect communities and emergency responders during periods of heightened vulnerability.

"Individuals who put our firefighters at risk and prey on communities when they are at their most vulnerable must be held accountable," Gabriel said.

"Looters—particularly those who impersonate emergency personnel— create chaos and confusion, endanger residents and first responders, and victimize communities that already have suffered unimaginable harm."

He said he worked with firefighters, police and first responders across California to develop the legislation.

The measures were introduced following reports of widespread looting and impersonation crimes following last year's Los Angeles County wildfires, when affected communities were recovering from significant loss and disruption.

The post New legislation targets looters and imposters at disaster sites first appeared on Moorpark Acorn.

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